Shansabani lineages functioned variably as elites and performed royalty quite differently from each other, conforming to the demands of the localized politico-economic and cultural circumstances of the areas respectively constituting their disparate bases of power.

Tiginabad /Old Qandahar

Excavations to the south of the historical site generally referred to as Old Qandahar, located 4 km west of modern Qandahar,[82] were conducted between 1974 and 1978 – the last to have been carried out there. They unearthed a long and surprisingly fluctuating history at the site, a mystery exacerbated by the varying names applied to the locale and its vicinity from the Hellenistic period onward. Although "Tiginabad" and "Old Qandahar" may appear anachronistic given these vagaries of naming, they are used here to focus on the settlement and its surrounding area's relevance specifically for Shansabani expansion during the second half of the twelfth century.[83]

The transit routes radiating southeastward from Herat, passing through the regions of Zamindawar and al-Rukhkhaj and ultimately reaching India, were as important as their northern counterparts toward Balkh, or again to India *via* Bamiyan and Kabul. Thus, the plains of al-Rukhkhaj were punctuated with settlements testifying to uninterrupted long-distance trade from the pre-historic eras onward (see also Chapter 2). Old Qandahar was among the locales benefiting from this continuous flow of people and goods through the region. Moreover, the fates of the city and its nearby Buddhist monastery were discernibly intertwined.

Looking down upon Old Qandahar and its plains was the famous Qaitul Buddhist complex (Figure 3.27) comprising a *vihara* and tall *stupa*, which still seems to command the vista from its prominence atop the Qaitul ridge. The Buddhist complex was founded quite possibly as early as the third century CE during the Mauryan presence in the region, and akin to most other Buddhist sites closely associated with travel routes, it served as a commercial node for the regularly passing traffic of merchants, pilgrims, and others. The Qaitul monastic establishment was actively patronized through the seventh or early eighth centuries CE, a span of time when Old Qandahar down on the plains was also a major emporium. The prosperity of both the city and the Buddhist complex was surely augmented by their proximity to Zamindawar, the regional *garm-sir* destination for the Rutbils undertaking seasonal transhumance between Zabulistan and al-Rukhkhaj-Zamindawar (see Chapter 2).

By the eighth century, however, the increasing conflagrations between these rulers and the incoming 'Umayyad and 'Abbasid deputies disrupted commerce and travel *via* the southern routes emerging from Herat. The